

Dryer Exhaust

Four numbers and one exception, all of them about lint and how far it can be pushed.

A dryer pushes hot, wet, lint-laden air out of the building. Every rule about the duct exists because lint settles wherever the air slows down, and settled lint is fuel sitting in a hot pipe.

The numbers here

Clothes dryer exhaust duct — diameter	4 in
Maximum developed length of the duct	35 ft
Transition duct between the dryer and the wall — maximum	8 ft
Fasteners joining sections must not project into the duct more than	1/8 in

Developed length means the real length including the penalty for every elbow, not the straight-line distance. Each bend costs several feet of the allowance, which is why a long duct with several turns fails the rule even when it measures under 35 feet on the tape.

The fastener rule follows the same logic. A screw projecting into the duct is a hook that catches lint, and the pile grows from there — which is why dryer ducts are joined with foil tape rather than screws.

The one exception on the whole building

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

What is required on all exterior air intake and exhaust systems except dryer vents?

A screen.

Screens keep birds, rodents and insects out of every other opening. A dryer vent is exempt for exactly the reason above — a screen would clog with lint within weeks. It gets a backdraft damper instead, which closes when the dryer is off.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. Dryer duct diameter and maximum developed length?
2. What does developed length mean, and why do elbows matter?
3. Maximum transition duct length?
4. How far may a fastener project into the duct, and why does it matter?
5. What is required on exterior openings, and which one is exempt?
6. What does a dryer vent get instead?